

WHY WE DON'T EAT PIG

The Instruction, the Evidence, and the Grace to Turn Around

A printable teaching handout. Scripture quoted from the World English Bible with the Names restored: YHWH, Yahshua, Elohim. Torah is referred to throughout as instructions, which is what the word means. Every scientific claim in this handout is linked to its source, so you can check it yourself.

YHWH never told Israel why. He did not owe them a reason, and He does not owe us one. Our obedience was never supposed to wait on a study confirming it. But when we do look, we find that He drew a line around the one animal whose flesh our own medicine treats as the closest working stand in for ours.

WHAT THIS HANDOUT COVERS

- The instruction itself, in Leviticus and Deuteronomy, with no reason attached.
- Why this was never a health code, and how clean and unclean were known long before Sinai.
- The prophets naming pig's flesh centuries later, in judgment language, not food safety language.
- Every passage used to say pork was made clean, answered one at a time.
- What modern science has found about pig flesh and human flesh, with sources linked.
- How to say it carefully, including where the claim is strong and where it is not.
- Grace for everyone who has eaten it, which is most of us.
- Answers to the pushback you will actually hear.

PART I

The Instruction, With No Reason Attached

The clean and unclean instructions are given in two places, and both name the pig specifically.

Leviticus 11:7-8

“The pig, because it has a split hoof, and is cloven-footed, but doesn’t chew the cud, is unclean to you. You shall not eat their meat. You shall not touch their carcasses. They are unclean to you.”

Deuteronomy 14:8

“The pig, because it has a split hoof but doesn’t chew the cud, is unclean to you. You shall not eat their meat. You shall not touch their carcasses.”

Notice what is missing. No explanation. No health warning. No reason offered at all. The standard is not what the animal has been through, it is what the animal **is**. A creature that chews the cud and has a split hoof is clean. The pig has the hoof and not the cud, so it is out.

Notice something else. The instruction goes past eating. Do not touch their carcasses. That is not a rule about digestion. That is a rule about separation.

Israel obeyed without knowing why. We are the generation that gets to read the lab reports.

And the chapter tells you the purpose, even while withholding the reason.

Leviticus 11:44-45

“For I am YHWH your God. Sanctify yourselves therefore, and be holy; for I am holy ... You shall therefore be holy, for I am holy.”

Set apart. That is what holy means. He set His people apart in what they carried in their bodies, not only in what they carried in their hearts. Peter quotes those very words to believers in **1 Peter 1:15-16**, long after the resurrection.

PART II

This Was Never a Health Code

The most common defense of pork is that the danger was parasites, and modern processing solved it. That answers a question YHWH never raised.

- **If the problem were parasites, the instruction would have been to cook it.** They knew how to cook meat in 1400 BC. He regulated other things by preparation. With the pig He did not regulate the preparation, He called the animal itself unclean.
- **Processing changes the condition of the meat. It does not change what the animal is.** A clean animal is clean before anyone processes anything.
- **He never revised it when butchering improved.** Centuries later the prophets are still naming pig's flesh, and food safety is nowhere in view.

There is also a timing problem for the idea that this was a temporary rule for one nation. Clean and unclean were already known long before Sinai, and before there was an Israel to give it to.

Genesis 7:2

“You shall take seven pairs of every clean animal with you, the male and his female. Of the animals that are not clean, take two, the male and his female.”

This is Noah, roughly eight hundred years before Moses. YHWH tells him to take clean animals by sevens and unclean by twos, and gives no definition. He does not have to. Noah already knew the difference.

PART III

The Prophets Kept Naming It

If this were only about a wilderness generation and their kitchens, it would not resurface in the prophets. It does, and in the strongest language in Scripture.

Isaiah 65:2-4

“I have spread out my hands all day to a rebellious people, who walk in a way that is not good, after their own thoughts ... who sit among the graves, and spend nights in secret places; who eat pig’s meat, and broth of abominable things is in their vessels.”

Isaiah 66:17

“Those who sanctify themselves and purify themselves to go to the gardens, following one in the middle, eating pig’s meat, abominable things, and the mouse, they shall come to an end together,” says YHWH.

Read Isaiah 66:17 in context. This is the closing chapter of Isaiah, and it is describing the end, when YHWH comes to gather the nations and set His glory among them. Pig's flesh is named there. Not in a health warning, and not in a list of temporary ordinances. In a judgment.

Isaiah 66:3 puts the offering of pig's blood alongside idolatry. The issue in these passages is people going their own way while calling themselves sanctified. Eating what He set apart from is treated as the visible evidence of it.

A note on the reference, because it comes up. The verse about those who eat swine's flesh being consumed at His return is Isaiah 66:17, not Isaiah 63. Isaiah 63 is the day of vengeance and the winepress. Get the citation right and no one gets to dismiss the point on a technicality.

PART IV

The Passages Used to Say Pork Was Made Clean

Before working through them, notice what is not there. No verse says the pig is now clean. No verse says the instruction was repealed. What exists is a set of passages about other subjects, stretched to imply it.

Mark 7:1-23

The claim: Yahshua declared all foods clean.

- **Read verse 2 and verse 5.** The subject of the whole passage is stated twice: the disciples ate with unwashed hands. That is a tradition of the elders, not an instruction from YHWH. Verse 8 names the actual problem: you set aside the commandment of God to hold your tradition.
- **The phrase in verse 19 is a translator's parenthesis** in most modern versions, and it follows a sentence about digestion. Whatever goes into the mouth passes into the stomach and out into the latrine.
- **The word food already meant food.** Nobody at that table considered pig to be food. To a first century Jewish audience, declaring foods clean means the clean things you eat with unwashed hands are still clean. It does not silently add the swine to the menu.
- **The passage ends where it began.** Verses 21 to 23 list what actually defiles a man, and it is a list of sins, then verse 23 closes the argument about the heart. Not one word about the dietary instructions.

Acts 10, Peter's vision

The claim: YHWH told Peter to kill and eat, so pork is clean.

- **Peter refuses**, and says he has never eaten anything unclean. This is years after the resurrection. If the instruction had been cancelled at the cross, the closest disciple to Yahshua never got the notice.
- **Peter himself interprets the vision**, and Scripture records his interpretation so we would not have to guess. Acts 10:28: God has shown me that I should not call any man unholy or unclean. Acts 10:34: God does not show favoritism.
- **The whole chapter is about Cornelius**, a Gentile. Three men are at the door before the vision ends. The vision was about who Peter could walk into, not what he could put on his plate.

1 Timothy 4:1-5

The claim: Every creature is good and nothing is to be refused.

- **Read verse 3.** Paul is describing false teachers who forbid marriage and command abstaining from foods. That is asceticism. Torah does not forbid marriage, so this cannot be a description of Torah keepers.
- **Verse 3 also limits the subject:** foods which God created to be received with thanksgiving **by those who believe and know the truth.** The pig was never created to be received as food.
- **Verse 5 gives the test:** it is sanctified through the word of God and prayer. Take it back to the word of God and the word of God says the pig is unclean. Prayer does not overrule the text it is appealing to.

Romans 14

- The dispute in the chapter is between one who eats all things and one who eats only vegetables. Nobody in Scripture was ever told to eat only vegetables. This is a meat sold to idols and personal conviction question in a mixed congregation, not a repeal of Leviticus 11.
- The pig is never mentioned in the chapter.
- Paul does not contradict Paul. In Acts 24:14 he says he believes all things written in the instructions and the prophets, and in Acts 25:8 he says he has committed no offense against them.

Colossians 2:16, 1 Corinthians 10:25, Genesis 9:3

Passage	What it actually addresses
Colossians 2:16	Paul says do not let anyone judge you for what you eat and drink and for the appointed times. He is defending the ones keeping them, not the ones abstaining. Verses 8 and 22 name the real problem: the tradition and commandments of men.
1 Corinthians 10:25-27	Meat sold in the marketplace, and the question of meat offered to idols. The Corinthian market question was whether it had been in a temple, not whether it was swine.
Genesis 9:3	Given to Noah, the same man who had just been told to load clean animals by sevens and unclean by twos, two chapters earlier. Whatever this verse permits, Noah did not understand it as erasing a distinction he had just been given.
Acts 15:19-21	The four requirements were a starting point for brand new Gentile believers, not a completed curriculum. Verse 21 says why: Moses is read in the synagogues every Sabbath, where they would learn the rest.

Every one of these passages is about something else. Not one of them says the pig is clean. You have to bring that conclusion to the text, because you cannot get it out of the text.

PART V

What Modern Science Found

None of this is the reason for the instruction. It is a witness that lines up with it. Every finding below is linked to its source. Check them yourself, and do not repeat any claim you have not looked at.

Transplants: medicine reaches for the pig

Pig tissue is not experimental. It is routine. Roughly **60,000 patients in the United States every year** receive heart valve replacements made from pig tissue, and those valves last around fifteen years ([Understanding Animal Research](#)).

In March 2024 a surgical team in China transplanted a six gene edited pig liver into a human recipient. It produced bile and pig albumin, held stable blood flow, and showed no sign of rejection across a **ten day** observation window. The study was published in *Nature* in 2025 ([Tao et al., Nature 2025](#)). Say this one accurately: the recipient was brain dead, and the pig liver was placed alongside the native liver rather than replacing it. It is still the first peer reviewed pig liver in a human body, and it still worked.

When modern medicine needs a stand in for human flesh, it does not reach for a cow, a sheep, a deer, or a goat. It reaches for the pig.

Genetics: the pig carries our genes

A 2025 USDA study in *BMC Genomics* manually assembled and annotated the pig proteome and compared pig, mouse, and human ([Dawson et al., BMC Genomics 2025](#)). Its findings:

- NCBI lists roughly **20,790 protein coding genes in pigs and 20,080 in humans**. Nearly identical counts.
- When a gene is missing from one of the three genomes, **pigs are 5.0 times more likely than mice to carry the human version**.
- When a functional domain is missing from a protein in one of the three species, pigs are **2 times more likely** than mice to have the human domain.

- Pigs can produce roughly **90 percent** of the human transcript variants tested, and pig to human mRNA conservation averages about 75 percent.

Immune system: we speak nearly the same language

Of the **419 CD immune markers** catalogued in humans, researchers have identified **359 corresponding proteins in pigs** ([Dawson and Lunney, 2018](#)). More broadly, the porcine immune system resembles the human immune system in more than **80 percent** of measured parameters, compared to about **10 percent** for the mouse ([Pabst, Cell and Tissue Research 2020](#)).

Skin: close enough to graft

Pig skin and human skin share general structure, thickness, hair follicle content, pigmentation, collagen and lipid composition, which is why the pig is the standard model for wound healing, burns, transdermal drug delivery, and dermal toxicity testing ([Summerfield, Meurens and Ricklin, Molecular Immunology 2015](#)). Both pig and human skin are fixed skin, attached to the tissue underneath, unlike rodent skin which is loose.

Fat and metabolism

The pig is used as a model for human obesity and metabolic syndrome because it is omnivorous like we are, tends toward sedentary behavior and fattening like we do, and shares metabolic and cardiovascular features with us ([swine metabolic syndrome study, PMC3354447](#)). Not one of the other clean animals named in Leviticus 11 sits in that seat.

PART VI

Say It Carefully

Truth does not need exaggeration, and one overstated claim will cost you the whole conversation. Here is where the line is.

- **Do not say the pig is the closest genetic match to humans.** It is not. Apes and primates are genetically closer, and that is not in dispute. The first person who knows it will use it to throw out everything else you said.
- **Say functional match instead.** No surgeon puts a chimpanzee valve in a human chest. No hospital grafts monkey skin onto a burn ward patient. The pig is the animal our own medicine treats as nearly interchangeable with us at the operating table. That claim is true, verifiable, and it hits harder.
- **Do not claim the differences do not exist.** They do. Burned pig skin does not behave mechanically like burned human skin ([Gallagher et al., Scientific Reports 2022](#)), and pig skin differs from human skin in stratum corneum thickness and blood vessel density. Naming the limits yourself is what makes the rest of it credible.
- **Do not build the instruction on the science.** If every finding here were reversed tomorrow, Leviticus 11:7 would still read exactly the same.

Obedience that waits for scientific permission is not obedience. It is negotiation.

PART VII

Why This Matters

He never told them why. He did not owe them a reason, and He does not owe us one. That has to be settled first, because our obedience was never supposed to be contingent on a study confirming it.

But when we do look, when the microscopes finally catch up, we do not find an arbitrary rule. We find a Father who drew a line around the one animal whose flesh most closely mirrors the flesh of the man He made in His own image.

Genesis 1:27

“God created man in his own image. In God’s image he created him; male and female he created them.”

The instructions were never a scoreboard. They are an invitation. A Father telling His children what is good for them and what is not. Science is only now arriving where Torah has been standing the whole time.

PART VIII

If You Have Eaten It

Hear this clearly. There is no condemnation waiting for you here.

Most of us ate pork our entire lives. We ate it at church potlucks. We ate it on Resurrection Sunday. We did not know, and YHWH is not standing over you with a record of every breakfast.

You do not obey to become His. You obey because you already are.

Repentance is not shame. It is just turning around. And the turn can start today, with the next meal, without a single argument won and without anyone else's permission.

PART IX

Answering the Pushback

“Modern processing killed the parasites.”

Processing answers a health objection that was never made. He did not say the pig would make you sick. He said the animal is unclean. Processing changes the condition of the meat. It does not change what the animal is. And if heat had solved it, the instruction would have been cook it well, not do not touch it.

“What God has cleansed, do not call common.”

Peter says that about people, and Scripture lets him tell you so himself in Acts 10:28. Read the verse he explains it with before you use the verse he heard in a trance.

“It is what comes out of the mouth that defiles.”

Yahshua said that while correcting a hand washing tradition, and He listed what He meant: evil thoughts, adultery, theft, murder, pride. He was not handing out a new grocery list. And the man who said it kept Torah perfectly His whole life. If He had eaten pig, He would have sinned, and we would have no Savior.

“You are being legalistic.”

Answer this one from the heart, not the argument. We are not saved by a diet. We are saved by the blood of Yahshua. We eat this way because we love Him, and because He said what He said and no man has the authority to unsay it. A gift is not legalism.

“Then why did He make pigs at all?”

He made plenty He never told us to eat. A vulture is not a failure of design. Pigs clear the ground of what dies on it, and there is no verse anywhere that says every animal was made to be dinner.

When to stop talking

If someone has already been handed the research and reached for the first thing that let them keep the bacon, more evidence will harden them. Take it back to what YHWH actually said, say it once, and love them. Their obedience is not your job. Their hearing it clearly is.

IN CLOSING

The Case in One Place

- He named the pig specifically, twice, and gave no reason.
- The standard is what the animal is, not what condition it is in.
- Clean and unclean were known in Noah's day, centuries before Sinai.
- The prophets were still naming pig's flesh centuries later, in judgment, not in food safety.
- Not one passage in the Renewed Covenant says the pig is clean. Every verse used is about something else.
- Our own medicine treats pig flesh as the closest working stand in for human flesh on earth.
- And none of that is the reason. The reason is that He said so.

Science is only now arriving where Torah has been standing the whole time.

APPENDIX A

Cross Reference Index

Theme	Passages
The instruction	Leviticus 11:1-8, 24-28; Deuteronomy 14:3-8
Purpose given: be holy	Leviticus 11:44-45; Leviticus 20:24-26; 1 Peter 1:15-16
Known before Sinai	Genesis 7:2, 8; Genesis 8:20
The prophets on pig's flesh	Isaiah 65:2-4; Isaiah 66:3; Isaiah 66:17
Mark 7 in context	Mark 7:2, 5, 8, 15, 19, 21-23; Matthew 15:1-20
Peter's vision explained	Acts 10:14, 28, 34-35; Acts 11:1-18
1 Timothy 4 in context	1 Timothy 4:1-5
Romans 14 in context	Romans 14:2, 6, 14, 15, 17, 21
Other passages cited	Colossians 2:8, 16, 22; 1 Corinthians 10:25-27; Genesis 9:3; Acts 15:19-21
Paul's own defense	Acts 24:14; Acts 25:8; Acts 28:17
The instructions still stand	Matthew 5:17-19; Romans 3:31; Romans 7:12; 1 John 2:3-4; 5:3; Revelation 12:17; 14:12
Made in His image	Genesis 1:26-27

APPENDIX B

Sources for the Science

Every link below was verified before this handout was printed. In the PDF the titles and addresses are clickable. On paper, type the address. Do not take anyone's word for it, including ours.

Genetics and genome

Dawson HD, Chen CT, Ragonese JS, Smith AD, Lunney JK. Verification and comparison of pig, mouse, and human genome similarities: use of manual assembly and analyses. *BMC Genomics*, 2025. Open access, USDA authors.

<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1186/s12864-025-12388-x>

Immune system

Dawson HD, Lunney JK. Porcine cluster of differentiation (CD) markers, 2018 update. *Research in Veterinary Science*, 2018. Source of the 419 human CD markers and 359 pig counterparts.

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/29518710/>

Pabst R. The pig as a model for immunology research. *Cell and Tissue Research*, 2020. Source of the 80 percent pig versus 10 percent mouse comparison.

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/32356014/>

Organs and transplants

Understanding Animal Research. Using pig livers to filter human blood. Source of the 60,000 US pig heart valve patients per year.

<https://www.understandinganimalresearch.org.uk/news/using-pig-livers-to-filter-human-blood>

Understanding Animal Research. Pig to human heart transplants: how did we get here? Background on bioprosthetic valves and their fifteen year lifespan.

<https://www.understandinganimalresearch.org.uk/news/how-did-we-get-to-pig-hearts-in-humans>

Tao KS, Yang ZX, Zhang X, et al. Gene modified pig to human liver xenotransplantation. *Nature*, 2025. The ten day pig liver study. Cite this rather than the news coverage of it.

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41586-025-08799-1>

Skin and tissue

Summerfield A, Meurens F, Ricklin ME. The immunology of the porcine skin and its value as a model for human skin. *Molecular Immunology*, 2015. Free full text at the University of Bern repository.

<https://boris.unibe.ch/66691>

Gallagher S, et al. Thermally damaged porcine skin is not a surrogate mechanical model of human skin. *Scientific Reports*, 2022. Included on purpose. This is the honest limit of the skin claim.

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8927453>

Fat and metabolism

Swine model study of metabolic syndrome and type 2 diabetes, National Library of Medicine, PMC3354447. Source for the pig as a model of human obesity and metabolic syndrome: omnivorous habits, propensity to fattening, shared metabolic and cardiovascular features.

<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC3354447>

Two sources to avoid

- **Commercial tissue vendor blogs.** The claims are mostly accurate but they sell porcine tissue for a living, and citing them hands a critic an easy dismissal.
- **The MYH4 muscle gene study.** It gets passed around as proof of similarity. It actually documents a difference: humans do not express that gene and pigs do. Citing it hands the argument away.

